

Subject: Important Housekeeping Email: Updated Git Workflow, DSPN Spring 2026

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From: Jeremy Hogeveen

To: Jeremy Hogeveen

Hi DSPN Students,

In class yesterday, we encountered a challenge for how I had planned to use Git for this course. When you modify files directly in a repository on your machines, and then try to “pull” any updates from my online repository, Git tries to merge your changes with the updates I’ve made. This causes “merge conflicts” or errors on your end that might be confusing and prevent you from successfully updating the course folder on your end. To keep things simple, I have a new recommendation for how to pull the latest notes from my Github, while retaining your own *working* version of the course files on your computer.

Specifically, I suggest you set up a **two-folders** system on your end. This would include 1. A “**source_folder**”: A read-only folder that you initially clone and then pull from before each lecture, and 2. A “**my_notes**” folder: Your personal workspace where you copy files to, take notes and work on code yourself, which doesn’t need to be linked to GitHub unless you want to use it for version control on your end (see [this lecture for reminder on version control in git](#)).

How to:

1. Create a base course folder / parent directory somewhere on your machine.
 - a. (e.g. “DSPN_2026” stored somewhere easy to navigate to such as Documents, Desktop, Home directory, etc.).
2. Open Terminal / Git Bash / Conda prompt and navigate (cd) to the course folder.
 - a. <cd /path/to/your/DSPN_2026>, press Return/Enter.
3. Clone the “source folder”.
 - a. <git clone https://github.com/JeremyHogeveen/dspn_spring2026_github>
— would be called dspn_spring2026_github
 - b. <git clone https://github.com/JeremyHogeveen/dspn_spring2026_github source_folder> — would be the same process, except the folder would now be called “source_folder”.
4. Create your “my notes” folder.
 - a. Still within terminal, or git bash, and still within your parent DSPN_2026 directory, type...
 - i. <mkdir my_notes>
 - b. If you’ve already made any custom notes so far in the course, move those files over to my_notes at this time (can use Finder for Mac or Windows Explorer if on a PC).
5. Your future workflow.

- a. Get the latest files from the course GitHub repository (in Terminal / Git Bash / Conda Prompt):
 - i. `<cd /path/to/your/DSPN_2026/source_folder>`
 - ii. `<git pull origin main>`
- b. Copy the updated files from the source_folder to the my_notes folder:
 - i. `<cd ..>` — to go back up to parent DSPN_2026 dir
 - ii. If on Mac/Linux:
 1. `<rsync -rP --update source_folder/ my_notes>`
Notes: rsync is maybe my most frequently used command in the terminal.
Notes2: -r is saying that this is a recursive call / will update all subdirectories, -P is to provide a progress tracker in the command window, and --update will make it so only the new files move over and the target directory folders do not get overwritten.
 - iii. If on Windows: open Windows PowerShell (should be easy to search in start menu).
 1. Use `<cd>` to navigate to your DSPN_2026 folder (e.g. `<cd C:\Users\jhogeveen\Desktop\DSPN_2026>` — slashes have flipped cause PowerShell likes Windows-style file paths)
 2. Type `<Copy-Item -Recurse .\source_folder\* .\my_notes\>`, press Enter
- c. Lastly, when you're ready to work, go back to Terminal / Git Bash / Conda Prompt.
 - i. `<conda activate dspn_env>`
 - ii. `<cd /path/to/your/DSPN_2026/my_notes/code>`
 - iii. `<jupyter lab>`

Why are we doing this?

- Will avoid any conflicts or potential data loss.
- Will ensure that you have all the functionality and requisite files that I have when I run code on the big screen.

Hot tip:

- *Note that Terminal, git bash, and Windows PowerShell all have long memories, so you don't have to type the steps for #5 every time! Just open the relevant command prompt, and use the "Up Arrow" button to show previously run commands.*

See you in tomorrow's lecture, and if you have any questions about the above please don't hesitate to reach out beforehand!

Cheers,
Jeremy

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